situations from coups to the neutralisation of precarious affairs inimical to Indian interests. The intelligence community fought adversaries with blood and guts, fuelled by strategies of the mind.

These unprecedented operations were not just limited to regional troublemakers like Pakistan. The R&AW recruited, trained and deployed informers and covert action teams in the USA, Iran and several European countries as well as India's immediate neighbours. All this was carried out with incredible confidentiality.

While most of the tales of spycraft in this book centre on male operatives, the R&AW has had female officers in plenty since the agency was born in 1968. Female secret operatives are recruited as analysts, cartographers, polygraph examiners, instructors, linguists, economists and targeting officers. Today, they are also cyber security experts, counterintelligence operatives, human resources specialists and so on. Working behind the scenes, they have shaped major operations, big events and the destiny of the nation.

For instance, a female friend of mine works as an analyst at the R&AW and has made immense contributions in tracking down terror financing in Pakistan. Analysts piece together raw intelligence from field agents and prepare finished products for the agency's customers. The R&AW's first customer is India's prime minister, which means, reports must include every relevant detail to enable better decisionmaking. There is no substitute for an analyst in the espionage profession. Armed with raw intel from the field, my friend led an operation that dragged Pakistan onto the grey list of the Financial Action Task Force, the intergovernmental organisation that keeps an eye on